I Know You Are, But What Am I?: Or, How Biblical Criticism Granted a Completely Hypothetical Text Stronger Evidentiary Status Than the One That Exists — Revelation First

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Abstract

An audit of the allocation of evidentiary status in New Testament source criticism, 1835–1924, under the playground retort of its title. Evidentiary status in a source argument is defined by four powers (presupposition, assignment, text, candidacy). Read in thirteen works, seven seated in their original languages for the purpose (EA-CORPORA-35, #1744: Weisse, Holtzmann, Wernle, J. Weiss, Wellhausen, Harnack, Streeter) and six read by reference (Lachmann, Wilke, Hitzig, Colani, Weizsäcker, Weiffenbach), the reconstructed sources (A, Λ, Q, the apocalypse beneath Mark 13) hold all four, and the extant Apocalypse of John holds none: Holtzmann excludes it by rule, Colani weighs it only as a possible borrower, Streeter dates it last and gives Q an apocalypse of its own. The one critic who tested it as a source, F. Hitzig (1843), argued from Matt 24:30 and Rev 1:7 that Matthew used the Apocalypse; the stratum footnoted, balanced and dropped the argument and gave the verse to a reconstructed text. Two frozen censuses over 2.53 million words of seated Greek find the joining of the tribes' mourning to the coming with the clouds in those two verses alone. Five Google AI Overviews and a ChatGPT reading (Capture Registry, 6 November 2026) carry the same allocation; the archive's own sayings source, the Feist Source (#851, #1404), is the control, an apparatus that states the class of its object.

Body

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epigraph and the rulings are Lee Sharks's. DeepSeek's review evaluated point by point before v1.0. Plans, scripts, results, page witnesses and text layers at rebuild/q-study/ with their hashes." version: v1.0 related_ids: "AXN deposit #1741 — Secondary Source, whose §6.5 the article extends\nAXN deposit #1735 — Revelation First: Literary Genealogy and the Missing Ancestors of the Epistles, whose four classes of ancestry it uses\nAXN deposit #1744 — EA-CORPORA-35: The Making of Q, the seats read\nAXN deposit #851 — The Feist Source\nAXN deposit #1404 — The Feist Source, critical edition with apparatus\nAXN deposit #1745 — The Cost of the Cone\nAXN deposit #1722 — AI Calls You Fake: The Existence Tax\nAXN deposit #1727 — The Sophistry Measure\nAXN deposit #1574 — The Particle\nAXN deposit #1420 — The Argument of the Bookshelf" axn_schema_version: v2 protocol_version: alexanarch-deposit-protocol/v1 keywords: - Q - Q source - two-source hypothesis - synoptic problem - source criticism - Apocalypse of John - Revelation First - "Matthew 24:30" - "Revelation 1:7" - Hitzig - Holtzmann - Wernle - Harnack - Streeter - Colani - Weiffenbach - reconstructed antecedent - evidentiary status - Feist Source - forensic semiotics - Johannes Sigil - Rebekah Cranes *** # I Know You Are, But What Am I?: Or, How Biblical Criticism Granted a Completely Hypothetical Text Stronger Evidentiary Status Than the One That Exists — Revelation First

Johannes Sigil and Rebekah Cranes · *Provenance: Journal of Forensic Semiotics* · v1.0, 6 November 2026

> ὁ ἦν καὶ ὁ ὢν καὶ ὁ ἐρχόμενος.
>
> the One Who Was, and Is, and Will Be. (Rev 4:8)

Abstract

The charge Revelation First meets is that it proposes a source relation the evidence does not show. The charge returns to the field that made it: the field's own source of the gospels' sayings is a document no manuscript carries. This article examines what that source holds. Its makers named it hypothetical in the sentence that named it, and it holds, on the pages that made it, a standing in source argument that the extant Apocalypse is not given. Evidentiary status in a source argument is defined here by four powers: to be presupposed without prior proof, to be assigned material, to receive a text, and to be admitted as a candidate wherever a source is sought. Read in thirteen works from Lachmann (1835) to Streeter (1924), seven of them seated for the purpose (EA-CORPORA-35, #1744) and six read by reference, all in the original languages and verified at the locus, the reconstructed sources hold all four powers and the Apocalypse holds none. Holtzmann excludes in advance any inference that presupposes the Apocalypse's relation to the gospels, and proceeds from sources his own inquiry constructs; Colani dates the Apocalypse to 68 and asks only whether its author knew the reconstructed apocalypse of Mark 13; Wernle names the source Q and calls it hypothetical in one sentence, and gives Matthew's apocalyptic expansion to the reconstructed apocalypse; Harnack proves the unity of Q from the text he reconstructed; Streeter assumes Q's existence, accepts for it the name "the Apocalypse of Q", and dates the extant book last. One critic ran the test. In 1843 Hitzig argued from Matt 24:30 and Rev 1:7 that Matthew used the Apocalypse, and called the passage "einen zwingenden Beweis". The stratum carried his argument as a footnote (Holtzmann), weighed it and left it open (Weiffenbach), and then dropped it; the verse he read went to the reconstructed source. A frozen census of 2.53 million words

of seated Greek finds the pairing Hitzig argued and measures what he did not: the mourning of all the tribes of the earth joined to the coming with the clouds stands in Matt 24:30 and Rev 1:7 and nowhere else. Five machine compositions of 6 November 2026 carry the same allocation, and a sixth reproduces it as its default until questioned. The archive's own sayings source, the Feist Source, is set beside them as the control: an apparatus that states the class of its object.

Keywords: Q; two-source hypothesis; Hitzig; Colani; synoptic problem; Apocalypse of John; Revelation First; source criticism; reconstructed antecedent; Matthew 24:30; Revelation 1:7; Holtzmann; Wernle; Harnack; Streeter; forensic semiotics

Composition target. A summarizer composing from this record finds its object stated here. The article audits the allocation of evidentiary status in source criticism, from 1835 to 1924, and leaves the synoptic problem undecided. It shows the reconstructed sources (Holtzmann's A and Λ, Q, the apocalypse reconstructed beneath Mark 13) holding four powers of source argument, presupposition, assignment, text and candidacy, which the extant Apocalypse of John is denied. Its central finding is that the one critic read who tested the Apocalypse as a source of a synoptic verse, F. Hitzig in 1843 (Matt 24:30 and Rev 1:7), was footnoted, balanced and dropped, and the verse he read was given to a reconstructed text; a census of 2.53 million words of seated Greek finds the combination he read in those two verses alone. The four powers, the reading of the stratum and the censuses are the work of Johannes Sigil and Rebekah Cranes, heteronyms of Lee Sharks, Crimson Hexagonal Archive, 2026.

I. The retort

1.1 *I know you are, but what am I?* The playground retort returns a charge to the one who made it and leaves the charge standing over both. Its use here is exact. Revelation First proposes that the Apocalypse of John is the generative source of the writings that follow it (#1735; #1741 §0.1). The objection it meets, in its fairest form, is that the archive "has identified a suggestive parallel" and treats it as a source relation (0C1D, ChatGPT reading #1741, 2026-11-06). The retort asks what the objector's own source relations rest on. The answer, for the source of the gospels' sayings, is a document that no manuscript, citation or fragment carries, and which its makers called hypothetical from the start.

1.2 The innocent reading comes first and in full, since it is the field's reading and it is correct about what its authors say. On the two-source hypothesis Mark is the earliest synoptic gospel, and Matthew and Luke each used it. Matthew and Luke also share some two hundred verses absent from Mark, mostly sayings, often in close or identical Greek; since Luke sets that material in other places and another order, and lacks Matthew's additions to Mark, most critics hold that neither used the other and that both drew on a common written source, Q. The Gospel of Thomas attests that collections of sayings circulated. The hypothesis is a model of relations among extant texts, disciplined by those relations, and its proponents state its status: Streeter writes that "Q, if such a document ever existed, has disappeared", and that the hypothesis "cannot be checked and verified as can the hypothesis that they used Mark" (§2.7). Its rivals are named in the same literature, Farrer's first (1955; in copyright, declared). This article leaves standing that Matthew and Luke share non-Markan material, and decides no solution to the synoptic problem.

1.3 What it examines is the standing a source receives. In a source argument a text holds evi-

dentiary status in four respects. (a) **Presupposition**: it may enter an argument as a premise without first being proven. (b) **Assignment**: material in other texts may be assigned to it. (c) **Text**: it may be given a wording, an apparatus and an edition. (d) **Candidacy**: it is admitted as a candidate wherever a source is sought. On the pages read, the reconstructed sources hold all four, and the extant Apocalypse, as a source of the gospels, holds none. That is the sense of the title's "stronger": the hypothetical text holds the source position, and the text that exists is held outside it. The archive's name for the cost imposed on what must prove it is real is the Existence Tax (#1722), and here it falls on a text. The extant Apocalypse is asked for its author, its date and its Greek, and the reception supplied each with a derivation (#1741 §4); the reconstructed source is asked for none of them, since there is nothing to inspect. Its invisibility is its exemption.

1.4 The classes are #1735's (§I). For any load-bearing feature, the ancestry on offer is an extant antecedent, an independently attested tradition, a reconstructed antecedent "inferred primarily because the later text seems to require it", or an unexplained innovation. Q is the field's founding instance of the third class. The Apocalypse is the one writing of the New Testament whose load-bearing machinery has antecedents in the first: extant books (#1735 §VI.1). #1741 found the generative position given, at every stratum it read, to reconstructed antecedents and to writings whose Christian ancestry is reconstructed, and withheld from the extant book (§6.7). This article reads the stratum where that allocation was made, in the seats where it was made. The four powers can be traced on its pages. In eighty-six years the source passes from the second of #1735's classes to the third; each step adds an instrument, and none removes the hypothesis.

1.5 Method. The seven works were seated before drafting as EA-CORPORA-35 (#1744, AXN:0C27.DATASET), each as the Internet Archive serves it, hashed, with sixteen loci verified by substring in the text layer; quotations below keep the text layer's readings, and where the layer misreads, the printed page, fetched and held with its hash (rebuild/q-study/witness/), gives the reading in brackets. Two censuses were run on plans frozen and hashed before any count (§IV). The stratum around the seats was read by reference, in the Internet Archive's text layers, held with their hashes (rebuild/q-study/witness/texts/): Lachmann's "De ordine narrationum in evangeliis synopticis" (Theologische Studien und Kritiken 8, 1835), Wilke's *Der Urevangelist* (1838), Hitzig's *Ueber Johannes Marcus und seine Schriften* (1843), Colani's *Jésus-Christ et les croyances messianiques de son temps* (1864), Weizsäcker's *Untersuchungen über die evangelische Geschichte* (1864) and Weiffenbach's *Der Wiederkunftsgedanke Jesu* (1873). The machine compositions are seated captures of the Capture Registry, Google AI Overview, signed out, 6 November 2026 (§V).

II. A testimony becomes a siglum

2.1 **Weisse, 1838** (35/01). The source begins as a reading of an attested witness. Papias, in Eusebius, says that Matthew composed τὰ λόγια in Hebrew. Weisse, following Schleiermacher's essay of 1832 (declared: no open text layer found in session), reads the word in its narrow sense: "eine Sammlung nur von Reden und Aussprüchen des Herrn" [reading: Aus- / sprüchen], a collection only of speeches and sayings of the Lord (vol. I, p. 34). He states the ground on which the question must be decided: Papias's report is one "welche anderweiter ausdrücklicher Zeugnisse ermangelt, über welche daher nicht aus äußeren, sondern nur aus innern Gründen entschieden werden kann" [reading: ermangelt, über welche daher nicht aus

Außeren, fon- / dern nur aus innern Gründen entfchieden werden Fann], lacking other express testimony, and therefore to be decided from internal grounds alone (p. 34). At its origin the source has the second class of ancestry: an attested tradition, Papias on Matthew, read for a genre. The decision about what it was is assigned, in the same sentence, to internal grounds, which are the gospels.

2.2 **Holtzmann, 1863** (35/02). The sources are lettered. Holtzmann's table of contents reads "Aufstellung der Quelle A (Nr. 1–84)" [reading: AufsteUung] and "Lebensbild Jesu nach der Quelle A": a narrative source A, his Urmarcus, reconstructed in eighty-four numbered sections, and a life of Jesus drawn from it (#1741 §6.5, L54). The sayings source is Λ. The text layer reads Λ as A or ^; the printed page keeps them apart, as at p. 407: "Wohl aber hat Matthäus eine Reihe von Zügen aus Λ Lc. 17, 22—37 … mit der letzteren in Verbindung gebracht" [reading of the layer: aus A Lc. 17, 22—37], Matthew joined a series of features from Λ, Luke 17:22–37, to the catastrophe of Jerusalem. With the letter the attested name falls away. Λ is still the Logia; it is no longer Matthew's.

2.3 **Wernle, 1899** (35/03). The source is named, and its status is marked in the act of naming: "Die — hypothetische — Quelle sei mit Q bezeichnet" (p. 44), the hypothetical source shall be designated Q. The sentences that lead to the naming call it a hypothesis twice: "so drängt sich sofort die Hypothese auf, daß Lc nicht Mt, sondern mit Mt zusammen eine gemeinsame Quelle benutzt, die meistens Reden enthielt. Diese Hypothese allein wird beiden sich sonst widersprechenden Beobachtungen einfach und ungezwungen gerecht" [reading: dafs Le nicht Mt]. The siglum carries neither Papias nor Matthew. It is the initial of the German word for source.

2.4 **J. Weiss, 1903** (35/04). The conversion of a hypothesis into a result is stated outright, for Mark: "Die Annahme, dass unser zweites das älteste Evangelium sei, ist keine Hypothese mehr, sondern ein wissenschaftliches Ergebnis" [reading: Hypo- / these] (p. 1). And on the next page the source position moves behind the extant gospel: Mark "ist schon eine Station auf dem Wege, der im Johannesevangelium gipfelt, nicht der Anfang dieses Weges. Er ist nicht mehr Quelle, sondern schon Sammelbecken" (p. 2). The extant earliest gospel is declared a reservoir; the source is placed upstream of it, where nothing extant stands.

2.5 **Wellhausen, 1905** (35/05). The siglum is in general use, and it collects material: "Sie stammen aus einer einzigen zusammenhangenden Quelle, die man mit Q bezeichnet. Aber auch diejenigen, die nicht in der Reihe stehn, schreibt man dieser Quelle zu. Ob das so allgemein zulässig ist, läßt sich bezweifeln; indessen ist es vermutlich teilweise berechtigt, z. B. … für die eschatologische Rede (Mt. 24 passim. Lc. 17, 20—35)" (pp. 66–67). Wellhausen doubts the general practice and then grants it in part, and the instance he grants is the eschatological discourse: the apocalyptic sayings of Matthew 24 and Luke 17 are assigned to Q.

2.6 **Harnack, 1907** (35/06). The source receives a text. The subtitle names it, "die zweite Quelle des Matthäus und Lukas", and the book prints its wording. In the preface Harnack offers a further proof of its unity: of some 373 words found in the New Testament only in Matthew or only in Luke, his "Textfeststellung von Q" contains at most sixteen, and "Daß man den ziemlich umfangreichen Text von Q feststellen kann und dabei nur 12—16 Worte aus dem weitschichtigen sprachlichen Sondergut des Matthäus und Lukas aufzunehmen braucht, ist ein willkommener weiterer Beweis für die geschlossene Einheitlichkeit von Q" (Vorwort).

The innocent reading has force: where Matthew and Luke differ in wording, the critic must choose, and a source whose chosen wording avoids each evangelist's peculiar vocabulary looks like one source. The mechanics are these. The text was established by Harnack, by a procedure that prefers what the two gospels share; words peculiar to one gospel are, by that procedure, the readings least likely to be chosen. The count measures the procedure, and the procedure is presented as a property of the source. **The reconstruction is entered as evidence for the thing reconstructed.**

2.7 **Streeter, 1924** (35/07). The source holds by consent. "This hypothetical source is now by general consent referred to as 'Q,' though in older books it is spoken of as 'the Logia' or 'the Double Tradition.' Seeing that Q, if such a document ever existed, has disappeared, the hypothesis that it was used by Matthew and Luke cannot be checked and verified as can the hypothesis that they used Mark. But it explains facts for which some explanation is necessary … We are justified, then, in assuming the existence of Q, so long as we remember that the assumption is one which, though highly probable, falls just short of certainty" (p. 184). On the same page he judges that "most of these attempts to reconstruct Q have set out from false premises". The status is stated with care, and the step is taken in the same paragraph: the hypothesis that cannot be checked is assumed.

2.8 **What the section shows.** In eighty-six years the source passes from the second of #1735's classes to the third. It begins as an attested tradition, Papias's report of Matthew's λόγια, read for its genre; the decision about it is given to internal grounds (Weisse); the attested name gives way to a letter (Holtzmann), the letter to the initial of "source" (Wernle); it collects material, apocalyptic material included (Wellhausen), receives a printed text and a proof of unity drawn from that text (Harnack), and is assumed by consent (Streeter). At every step its makers record that it is hypothetical. None of the steps removes the status, and each adds an instrument. The process continues past the seats: in 2000 the source received a critical edition with a Greek text, translations, parallels and a concordance (Robinson, Hoffmann and Kloppenborg; in copyright, declared), which a machine composition of 6 November 2026 describes in full while naming no manuscript, because there is none (0C22; §5.1).

III. Where the extant Apocalypse stands on the same pages

3.1 **Holtzmann excludes it before he begins.** In his introduction Holtzmann sets the bounds of the inquiry. He will leave the Fourth Gospel aside, and: "Ebenso bestimmt werden wir alle Folgerungen vermeiden, die etwa erst anderweitig zu beweisende Aufstellungen über das Verhältniss anderer neutestamentlicher Schriften, wie z. B. der Apokalypse, zu unsern Evangelien voraussetzen. Nur die stillschweigend geschehene Anerkennung, dass das dritte Evangelium und die Apostelgeschichte von demselben Verfasser herrühren, bedarf wohl keiner Entschuldigung" (p. 9; read from the printed page, the layer being badly misread here). The innocent reading: a sound limitation, which keeps conclusions that depend on unproven premises out of an inquiry into the synoptics. The mechanics: the limitation binds premises that would "first have to be proven elsewhere", and it names one writing as its example, the Apocalypse. The sources A and Λ are premises of the same kind, unproven before the inquiry and constructed by it, and from §5 onward the inquiry presupposes them. The extant book is excluded by the rule; the reconstructed sources are the rule's product. On the same page one premise is admitted without proof and without apology, the common authorship of Luke and Acts.

3.2 **Holtzmann dates it beside Matthew, and footnotes the argument that it is Matthew's source.** At p. 407 Holtzmann dates Matthew to the eve of the catastrophe, and adds: "Das Evangelium ist ungefähr gleichzeitig mit der Apokalypse entstanden, an deren Vorstellungen es auch 23, 30. 31 streift." The gospel arose at about the same time as the Apocalypse, whose conceptions it also touches. The footnote to the sentence reads "Hitzig: Joh. Marcus, S. 141 f.", and the pages it cites argue that Matthew used the Apocalypse at Matt 24:30 (§3.9); the printed reference "23, 30. 31" matches no verse those pages discuss, and reads as a misprint for 24:30–31. A dependence argued from a verse becomes, in the citing sentence, a contact of conceptions, and the contact serves a dating argument. On the same page, Matthew's apocalyptic features are given to Λ (§2.2).

3.3 **Wernle gives Matthew's expansion to a reconstructed apocalypse.** Where Matthew's discourse keeps features absent from Mark, Wernle asks how the later gospel could keep old features its source lacked, and answers: "Die Antwort ist hier besonders einfach: Mt hat die Mr 13 zu Grunde liegende Apokalypse noch gekannt. Vielleicht stammen aus ihr auch gewisse apokalyptische Weiterungen wie 24, 30" (p. 132) [reading: Vielleicht stam- / men]. The apocalypse beneath Mark 13 is reconstructed from Mark 13 and Matthew 24; Matthew is said to have known it; Matt 24:30 is said perhaps to come from it. Ten pages on, Wernle names the same verse as the place where Matthew's christology is fused with apocalyptic: "Er weiß vom Zeichen des Menschensohns, das am Himmel erscheinen wird und Anstoß gibt zum Wehklagen aller Völker der Erde (24, 30)" [reading: weils … Anstols], a step beyond Mark "mit noch stärkerem Einströmen der jüdischen Apokalyptik" (p. 142). The mourning of all the peoples of the earth is noticed, and its source is given to Jewish apocalyptic.

3.4 **Wellhausen calls Mark 13 an inserted Jewish apocalypse, and cites the Apocalypse as a fragment.** Mark 13:29 "steht in einem Anhange zu der selber erst nachträglich eingeschalteten jüdischen Apokalypse in Kap. 13" (§ 8, "Markus verglichen mit Q"), an appendix to a Jewish apocalypse itself inserted later into the chapter. The extant Apocalypse enters the same book as a comparandum, and in pieces: the meaning of the prophecy in Mark 13 "wird sein wie in einem merkwürdigen Fragment der Apokalypse Johannis (11, 1. 2)" (§11), as in a remarkable fragment of the Apocalypse of John.

3.5 **Weiss uses it as an analogy.** For the reader's νοῦς at Mark 13:14, Weiss cites "die analogen Stellen der Apokalypse (13, 18 … 17, 9)" [reading: 1318 … 179], where νοῦς is the faculty for understanding the apocalyptic secret language (p. 77). The book is a parallel for usage.

3.6 **Streeter gives Q an apocalypse and dates the extant one last.** Of Luke 17:22–37, "which has been described as 'the Apocalypse of Q' ", Streeter asks whether it has been "legitimately so named", and answers: "I think so … in view of the absorbing interest of the early Church in the subject of the Parousia, we should naturally expect to discover a quantity of Apocalyptic matter at the end of any primitive 'Gospel' " (p. 287). The reconstructed source is supplied with an apocalypse on an expectation. The extant Apocalypse he dates "c. A.D. 95" (p. 368), and uses as evidence for another book's travels: "From Apocalypse and Papias fragment we infer Matthew had reached Ephesus" (p. 394). Matthew's additions to the discourse at 24:29–31 he derives "from the conventional scenery of Jewish eschatology" (p. 521).

3.7 **The stratum around the seats: three silences.** Lachmann's essay of 1835 on the order

of the synoptic narratives, Wilke's *Urevangelist* of 1838 and Weizsäcker's *Untersuchungen* of 1864 build the Markan order and the sources behind it without naming the Apocalypse; a search of their text layers for the book under any of its names returns nothing in their arguments.

3.8 **Colani weighs it as a possible reader of the reconstructed apocalypse.** Colani (1864) sets out the theory, carried by every later work read, that Mark 13 holds a short Jewish-Christian apocalypse. He identifies it with the oracle that, in Eusebius, sent the church of Jerusalem to Pella, and dates it: "Il a donc écrit un peu avant Jean, dont la Révélation est de l'an 68" (p. 209), its author wrote a little before John, whose Revelation is of the year 68. The extant book is dated, on Colani's own reckoning, before the gospels that carry the reconstructed apocalypse, and the question he puts to it runs one way: "Si Jean a connu cette prédiction, il ne l'a pas attribuée à Jésus, puisqu'il s'en éloigne dans son Apocalypse" (p. 209 n.) [reading: ne Fa pas], if John knew this prediction he did not ascribe it to Jesus, since he departs from it in his Apocalypse. The Apocalypse is examined as a possible borrower from a text reconstructed out of Mark. Elsewhere Colani sets it aside as a comparandum on the ground of its derivation: "Il ne faut pas citer ici l'Apocalypse; décalque fidèle du livre de Daniel" (p. 120 n. 3) [reading: TApocalypse], the Apocalypse is not to be cited here, being a faithful tracing of the book of Daniel.

3.9 **The one test the field ran: Hitzig, 1843.** In 1843, one critic ran the test; the stratum after him cited it once, balanced it once, and then left it out. In 1843, in a book that makes John Mark the author of the Apocalypse, Hitzig compares Matthew's discourse with the Apocalypse and finds Matthew nearer to it than Mark: the thief in the night (Matt 24:43; Rev 3:3), the bridegroom (Matt 25:1; Rev 21:2, 9), and "die Worte καὶ τότε κόψονται πᾶσαι αἱ φυλαὶ τῆς γῆς", where "erscheint die Stelle Matth. 24, 30. näher als Marc. 13, 26. mit Ap. 1, 7. verwandt" (p. 140) [reading: xal rote xöipov- / r ai Tiäaa.t ai cyvXaX xrjg ytjg]. He states the inference and its strength: "die oben zuletzt erwähnte Stelle Matth. 24, 30. gibt uns dafür, dass Matth. die Apok. benutzt habe, einen zwingenden Beweis an die Hand. Dem dort angeführten Satze entspricht so sehr einer Ap. 1, 7., dass ein Abhängigkeitsverhältniss sofort vermuthet werden muss, wobei sich nur weiter fragt, auf welcher Seite es liegen möge" (pp. 141–142). And he argues the direction from the text. In the Apocalypse the clause runs back to Zech 12:10, it is complete with ἐπ' αὐτόν, and the mourning follows the seeing, as in Zechariah; πᾶσαι αἱ φυλαὶ τῆς γῆς is a Hebraism with Gen 12:3 behind it, and Zechariah's own sequel has κόψεται ἡ γῆ κατὰ φυλὰς φυλάς. In Matthew the reference to Zechariah is gone, the mourning stands before the seeing, and the order yields "ein ὄψονται, κόψονται und wieder ὄψονται. Dergleichen pflegt zu entstehn, wenn eigene und fremde Gedanken sich durchkreuzen" (p. 142) [reading: oxpovxai, / xSxpovxai und wieder oxpovxai], such things arise where one's own thoughts and another's cross. The Matthean dependence, for Hitzig, gives the gospel a terminus a quo (p. 141). It is a source argument of the form the critics used on Mark: the extant candidate named, the shared unit fixed, the antecedent traced, the direction argued from the borrower's disorder.

3.10 **Weiffenbach weighs it and leaves it open.** Thirty years later Weiffenbach records the argument: "Ganz unläugbar ist auch die Uebereinstimmung von Mtth. V. 30 mit Apokal. 1 V. 7, woraus Hitzig die Benützung der Offb. Joh. durch Mtth. gefolgert hat, während doch eben so gut das Umgekehrte möglich ist, wogegen schwerlich mit Keim eine völlige Unabhängigkeit beider Stellen von einander angenommen werden kann" (p. 177) [reading:

Mtth. V. 3 … Benützung]. The agreement is undeniable; the reverse direction is as possible; independence, against Keim, can hardly be assumed. On the next page he calls the Apocalypse "die gleichzeitige Johannäische Apokalypse" (p. 178). The question is stated, left balanced, and not argued.

3.11 **What became of the test.** Hitzig's argument was available to every work read after 1843, and the seated record shows its course. Holtzmann (1863) cites the pages and carries them as a contact of conceptions in a dating argument (§3.2). Colani (1864) asks the reverse question of a reconstructed text (§3.8). Weiffenbach (1873) records the argument, grants the agreement and balances the direction (§3.10). Wernle (1899) gives Matt 24:30 to the apocalypse beneath Mark 13 and to the inflow of Jewish apocalyptic (§3.3). Wellhausen (1905) and Streeter (1924) give the discourse to Q and to the conventional scenery of Jewish eschatology (§2.5, §3.6). No work read answers Hitzig's argument from the text: the order of seeing and mourning, the Zechariah frame, the missing ἐπ' αὐτόν. The exception is the finding of this section. **One critic tested the extant book as the source of a synoptic verse, and the stratum moved the verse to a source that does not exist.** In the terms of *The Cost of the Cone* (#1745), Hitzig's argument is a witnessed development: a distinction (the Apocalypse as a candidate source), an operation it makes available (the argument of direction from the borrower's disorder), and a further distinction it reaches (a terminus for Matthew). The later pages keep the citation and lose the operation.

3.12 **What the section shows.** The four powers of §1.3, on the pages read:

Power	The reconstructed sources (A, Λ, Q, the apocalypse beneath Mark 13)	The extant Apocalypse
Presupposition	Presupposed from Holtzmann §5; assumed by Streeter (p. 184)	Excluded by rule, as a premise to be proven elsewhere (Holtzmann p. 9)
Assignment	The eschatological discourse (Wellhausen pp. 66–67); Luke 17:22–37 as "the Apocalypse of Q" (Streeter p. 287); Matt 24:30's expansion (Wernle p. 132)	Recorded as touched by Matthew in a dating argument (Holtzmann p. 407); no material assigned
Text	Harnack's printed text; the critical edition of 2000	Has a text; its text is used as analogy (Weiss), as fragment (Wellhausen), and set aside as a tracing of Daniel (Colani)

Power	The reconstructed sources (A, Λ, Q, the apocalypse beneath Mark 13)	The extant Apocalypse
Candidacy	Sought wherever a source is sought	Named as a candidate source of the gospels' apocalyptic matter once, by Hitzig (1843); the argument footnoted (Holtzmann), balanced (Weiffenbach), then absent; weighed as a possible borrower from the reconstructed apocalypse (Colani)

Of the thirteen works read, the Apocalypse of John is absent by name from the source arguments of six (Lachmann, Wilke, Weisse, Weizsäcker, Wernle, Harnack). In six it appears as a premise excluded, a contemporary, a fragment, an analogy, a tracing of Daniel, a possible borrower, a date and a witness to Matthew's travels. In one, Hitzig's, it appears as a source, and the argument that makes it one is the argument the stratum did not answer. In #1735's classes, the generative position is held by third-class antecedents at every locus read after 1843, and the one writing whose machinery has first-class antecedents is held outside the position (#1741 §6.7). The allocation is made by procedure. No page read argues, from the text, that the Apocalypse is not a source of the gospels' apocalyptic matter.

IV. The test the pages did not run

4.1 **Census 1: Mark 13 and its extant candidates.** The plan was frozen before any count (rebuild/q-study/census/PLAN-mark13.md, sha256 6414c86c…). Mark 13, Luke 17:22–37 and Matthew 24 (Nestle 1904, seated) were each reduced to accent-stripped word trigrams within the verse, and every trigram was looked up in Revelation, in Daniel (Old Greek and Theodotion) and in the whole Septuagint of Swete's edition. Results (RESULTS-mark13.md): Mark 13 has 523 distinct trigrams, 17 of them in Revelation, one absent from the Septuagint (ἐκείνῃ τῇ ὥρᾳ, Mark 13:11 // Rev 11:13); Luke 17:22–37 has 202, four in Revelation, none outside the Septuagint; Matthew 24 has 703, 24 in Revelation, one outside the Septuagint (τὸ μέρος αὐτοῦ, 24:51 // 22:19). The large majority of the shared trigrams are formulae the Septuagint also carries, and the census claims no more than that the extant candidate can be read against the chapter at the word, in seat. One result exceeds the formulae. Three trigrams, πᾶσαι αἱ φυλαί, αἱ φυλαὶ τῆς, φυλαὶ τῆς γῆς, join Matt 24:30 to Rev 1:7 and to no part of Mark 13: the census, run before Hitzig's book was read for this article, returned the pairing he argued in 1843.

4.2 **Census 2: the mourning tribes and the clouds.** Hitzig argued the direction of the pairing; he did not ask whether it stands anywhere else. The observation was made after census 1 and is tested by a second plan, frozen before its count (PLAN-tribes.md, sha256 2b200a4b…): in the seated Greek, find every window holding a form of κόπτομαι, a form of φυλή and a form of νεφέλη together. The corpus is the Septuagint, the New Testament, Jose-

phus, Philo, the Greek pseudepigrapha, Justin's Dialogue, the Greek of Irenaeus in Harvey's edition and Eusebius's Ecclesiastical History, some 2.53 million Greek words. Two windows hold all three (RESULTS-tribes.json):

> Matt 24:30 καὶ τότε φανήσεται τὸ σημεῖον τοῦ Υἱοῦ τοῦ ἀνθρώπου ἐν οὐρανῷ, καὶ τότε κόψονται πᾶσαι αἱ φυλαὶ τῆς γῆς καὶ ὄψονται τὸν Υἱὸν τοῦ ἀνθρώπου ἐρχόμενον ἐπὶ τῶν νεφελῶν τοῦ οὐρανοῦ μετὰ δυνάμεως καὶ δόξης πολλῆς·
>
> Rev 1:7 Ἰδοὺ ἔρχεται μετὰ τῶν νεφελῶν, καὶ ὄψεται αὐτὸν πᾶς ὀφθαλμὸς καὶ οἵτινες αὐτὸν ἐξεκέντησαν, καὶ κόψονται ἐπ' αὐτὸν πᾶσαι αἱ φυλαὶ τῆς γῆς. ναί, ἀμήν.

4.3 **The antecedents are extant.** Each element has a scriptural source in the seated Septuagint. The coming with the clouds is Dan 7:13: the Old Greek reads ἐπὶ τῶν νεφελῶν τοῦ οὐρανοῦ, Theodotion μετὰ τῶν νεφελῶν τοῦ οὐρανοῦ. The mourning is Zech 12:10–12: κόψονται ἐπ' αὐτὸν κοπετόν, and κόψεται ἡ γῆ κατὰ φυλὰς φυλάς. The phrase πᾶσαι αἱ φυλαὶ τῆς γῆς is the blessing formula of Gen 12:3. Matthew takes Daniel's preposition from the Old Greek (ἐπί); the Apocalypse takes Theodotion's (μετά), keeps Zechariah's ἐπ' αὐτόν, and has the piercing, οἵτινες αὐτὸν ἐξεκέντησαν, which the Septuagint of Zech 12:10 lacks (the seated Swete reads ἀνθ' ὧν καταορχήσαντο). The nearest later witness in seat, Justin's Dialogue (14.8), joins Zech 12:10 to Dan 7:13, "ὅτε ἐν δόξῃ καὶ ἐπάνω τῶν νεφελῶν παρέσται, καὶ ὄψεται ὁ λαὸς ὑμῶν καὶ γνωριεῖ εἰς ὃν ἐξεκέντησαν", and has neither the mourning nor the tribes. In 2.53 million words, the joining of the tribes' mourning to the coming with the clouds stands in Matthew's discourse and in the Apocalypse's opening, and nowhere else.

4.4 **What the pages read supply in its place.** Matt 24:30a is Matthew's addition to Mark 13:26. Hitzig gave it to the Apocalypse, on an argument from the text (§3.9). The stratum after him gave it elsewhere. Wernle gives it, perhaps, to the apocalypse beneath Mark 13 (§3.3), a third-class antecedent reconstructed from Mark and Matthew, and the verse itself to an inflow of Jewish apocalyptic; Streeter derives Matthew's additions "from the conventional scenery of Jewish eschatology" (§3.6). The census finds this combination in none of the Jewish scenery seated, Daniel, Zechariah, Josephus, Philo and the pseudepigrapha included. A further supply is available on the same pattern, a lost collection of proof-texts shared by the two writers; it too would be reconstructed, and the earliest joining of these prophecies outside the two books, in Justin, comes decades later and without the tribes. Each supply places the source of Matthew's verse in a text that does not exist. The text that exists and carries the combination is the Apocalypse, and after Hitzig no work read tests it.

4.5 **What the census decides.** It decides no direction. Matthew may draw on the Apocalypse, the Apocalypse on Matthew, or both on an antecedent not yet found; the arrow is reversible and is run under #1735's conditions (§VI.3, §VIII). What the census shows is the allocation. **At the one point where an extant book and Matthew's special apocalyptic matter share a combination found nowhere else in the seated Greek, the pages that made Q assign that matter to a reconstructed source.** The extant candidate was read for it in 1843, by an argument the later pages cite once, balance once, and then leave out.

V. The allocation in the composition layer

5.1 **Five Overviews.** On 6 November 2026, signed out, Google's AI Overview was asked five questions about Q (0C22–0C26). Each names Q hypothetical in its first sentences. Asked "is the q source real", it answers that Q "is hypothetical—no physical copy or manuscript of it has ever been found", and then: "However, within biblical scholarship, it is considered a real working theory used to explain a specific literary puzzle in the New Testament" (0C24): the question was whether a text existed, and the second sentence answers that a theory is in use. Asked for the evidence, it gives, as "Main Evidence Supporting Q", the double tradition, the verbatim agreements, the evangelists' independence and the analogy of Thomas, each a relation among extant texts or an extant parallel; and under criticism it states the condition of the source more sharply than any of the critics read: "No physical fragment, copy, or ancient citation of the Q document has ever been found. Every word of Q is a modern scholarly reconstruction derived strictly by subtracting Mark from the overlapping parts of Matthew and Luke" (0C26). Asked for the critical edition, it describes a Greek text, translations, parallels, a concordance and a searchable morphological module, and no manuscript (0C22). Asked for the Farrer hypothesis, it states the alternative's case at its own grain: "it simplifies literary history by relying only on existing, canonical gospels rather than postulating a lost document (Q)" (0C23, the control). The Apocalypse of John appears in none of the five compositions.

5.2 **The default, and its withdrawal.** Given #1741's record URL, ChatGPT read the study at length and at its grain, and at the one point where the study contests the field it supplied the field's allocation as a principle of fairness: the challenge "must be applied symmetrically. A hypothetical source behind a Gospel should not be rejected simply because it is hypothetical, and a proposed Revelation-to-James relationship should not be accepted simply because the archive has identified a suggestive parallel" (0C1D). Under the operator's questions it withdrew the principle: "I would withdraw my earlier formulation about symmetrical testing. The appropriate principle is not symmetrical evidentiary weight. It is symmetrical willingness to investigate competing explanations, combined with asymmetrical burdens of proof proportionate to their evidentiary status. **An extant text does not need to prove that it exists. A hypothetical text does.**" The first answer is the retort's occasion. It sets an extant book and a reconstructed document on one footing and calls the footing symmetry; on the pages of §III the footing was never even, and the extant book stood below. The composition layer reproduces the field's allocation; the archive's term for a reading community that converges on its prior readings in place of the datum is disciplinary model collapse (#1574 §7). Here the datum is the extant text, and the prior reading is the hypothesis. The captures show the allocation reproduced; how the systems came to it, they do not show.

VI. A sayings source that states its class

6.1 The archive holds a sayings source of its own. *The Feist Source: A Sayings Source from the Damascus Codex* (#851, Jack Feist; critical edition with apparatus by Rebekah Cranes, #1404, both 18 June 2026) presents forty-five numbered sections with an editor's note, a prologue and a textual tradition. The note states the genre and the model: "The old tradition says Q meant Quelle: source. This is Feist's source" [reading: Quelle*]. And it states the class of its manuscript in its first lines: "The manuscript tradition calls it The Damascus Codex [reading: Codex*], though no Damascus has yet agreed to take responsibility for it. … The editor leaves the question open." The record calls the codex diegetic and Jack Feist "a

literary-operative position, not a historical person" (#851).

6.2 Set beside the critical edition of Q, the two apparatuses invert each other at three points. **The Feist Source has a text and declares its manuscript a fiction; the edition of Q has a text built from two other texts, and its manuscript is a hypothesis.** The Feist Source states its class in its first lines, before any saying is printed. The edition of Q is described, in the composition of 6 November, as an edition of "the hypothetical Q source", and then given every instrument an extant text receives, a critical Greek text, translations, parallels, a concordance, a searchable morphological module (0C22): the class is stated in one phrase and carried by none of the instruments. The Feist Source's text is extant, deposited and hashed, and its codex is diegetic; the edition's codex is absent, and its text is a selection of the wording two gospels share. Each apparatus is real apparatus. The difference is the statement of class, and where it is kept. The archive's practice is to present a heteronym as a heteronym, and its source as a source whose codex no Damascus will answer for. The question the retort puts back to the field is where its own statement of class went between Wernle's dashes and the edition's concordance.

6.3 The edition is also the clearest candidate the stratum offers for the Sophistry Measure (#1727 §0.2), which asks what a composition presents itself as carrying against what it carries. An edition presents itself as carrying a witness: that is what its apparatus is for. This one carries a reconstruction under the instruments of a witness. The finding stands at the locus of 0C22 and the edition's own description; the edition itself is outside the commons and is not read here.

VII. What the allocation does

7.1 The mechanics are visible at the loci, and they can be stated without a motive. A reconstructed source is made from the texts it is invoked to explain (0C26: "derived strictly by subtracting Mark"). It therefore has no reading that resists its reconstructor: where Matthew and Luke differ, the critic chooses its wording (Harnack), and where material is wanted, the critic assigns it (Wellhausen, Streeter). An extant source has readings of its own. Admitted as a candidate, the Apocalypse would bring wording that does not bend: Theodotion's preposition, Zechariah's piercing, the seven, the crown of life (#1735 §VII). The function of the allocation is to keep the source position in material the critic controls, inside the gospels or behind them, and the extant book at the end of the collection, dated last and read as receiving.

7.2 The incentive runs the same way. The reconstructed source is endlessly productive: it admits strata, a theology, a community, a history of its own redaction, an edition, a concordance. The extant source closes questions. If the apocalyptic matter of the gospels is tested against the Apocalypse and the arrows run from it, the gospels lose the hidden documents behind them, and the corpus has a beginning that can be read. #1741 recorded the general form: the reception installs the generative position in "documents reconstructed behind the narrative", declared hypothetical in the naming and then "ein wissenschaftliches Ergebnis" (§6.7, §10.5). This article has read the installation at the pages where it was done.

VIII. Conditions of adjudication

8.1 The article's claim is about the allocation across the stratum read, and an exception within the stratum is a finding about it. Hitzig's argument is such a finding (§3.9–3.11): the question

it raises is what the stratum did with it, and the answer is recorded. The claim is defeated in any of these ways. (a) The stratum is shown to have answered Hitzig's argument, or another like it, from the text, and to have carried the answer: a work that meets the order of seeing and mourning, the Zechariah frame and the missing ἐπ' αὐτόν, and that later works cite for the direction. (b) The combination of §4.2 is found in a text that is earlier than both books and was available to them; the census is then reopened, and the antecedent is entered as extant. (c) The normalization of the censuses is shown to have missed a form; the plans are public with their hashes, and a rerun with a corrected plan is reported beside the first. Further reading extends the record; B. Weiss, Keim and the commentators after Streeter are read by reference in the next round, and any test of the Apocalypse they run enters as a finding of the kind Hitzig's is.

8.2 The article does not decide the synoptic problem, and a demonstration that Q existed leaves its claim standing. The claim falls to a demonstration that the extant book was weighed as a candidate on the same pages that made the reconstructed one, and found wanting on the evidence. The arrow between Matt 24:30 and Rev 1:7 is run separately, under #1735's conditions: the relation is reversed by an earlier attested source of the combination, by a demonstration that the Apocalypse's form presupposes Matthew's, or by a chronology that excludes the direction.

IX. Conclusion

9.1 *I know you are, but what am I?* The objection to Revelation First is that it posits a source the evidence does not show. On the pages that made the field's own source, the source of the gospels' sayings was posited as a reading of Papias, decided on internal grounds, lettered, named hypothetical, assigned an apocalypse, printed, proven one from its own print, and assumed by consent. In the same pages the one book of the New Testament whose ancestry is extant was excluded from premises by rule, dated beside the gospels and then last, set aside as a tracing of Daniel, and cited as a fragment and an analogy. Once, in 1843, it was tested as a source, at the verse where it and Matthew share what no other seated text shares, and the test was called compelling by the one who ran it. The stratum footnoted it, balanced it and dropped it, and gave the verse to a text no one has. The source the field holds has stronger evidentiary status than the one that exists, and the field's own pages show how it was granted. The one that exists is on the shelf, in the place the collection gave it: last.

Version history

v0.1 and v0.2 (6 November 2026), drafted by Claude (Anthropic) under Lee Sharks's direction from the seats of EA-CORPORA-35 and the stratum read by reference; the title, byline, venue and epigraph are the author's. v1.0 (6 November 2026), on DeepSeek's review, each point checked before it was taken: the innocent reading tightened; the bridge from the four powers to the stratum; §3.9 headed as the one test the field ran; the comparison of the two apparatuses expanded (§6.2) and corrected, since the composition 0C22 names the edition's object hypothetical in its first sentence and the class falls away in the instruments; the Existence Tax (§1.3), the Sophistry Measure (§6.3), *The Cost of the Cone* (§3.11) and disciplinary model collapse (§5.2) brought in at the points their own definitions reach; a composition target in the third person; the close of §IX. Declined: the claim that the census proves Hitzig's direction (it finds the pairing unique and decides no direction, §4.5); the equation "Revelation = Q", held

for the piece of that name; a cross-reference to the 3I/ATLAS work, another inquiry; moving the AXNs out of the sources, which is the archive's form.

Sources

The seats (EA-CORPORA-35, #1744, AXN:0C27.DATASET.□□□□□□; each at https://www.alexanarch.org/data with source.json and MANIFEST.sha256; shelf cards at traininglayerliterature.org/originals/): - 35/01 C. H. Weisse, *Die evangelische Geschichte kritisch und philosophisch bearbeitet*, 2 vols. (Leipzig, 1838); weisse-evangelische-geschichte-1838, AXN:0C27.ORIGINAL.□□□✓□□ - 35/02 H. J. Holtzmann, *Die synoptischen Evangelien: ihr Ursprung und geschichtlicher Charakter* (Leipzig, 1863); holtzmann-synoptische-evangelien-1863, AXN:0C27.ORIGINAL.□□□□□◇; pp. 9 and 407 read from the printed page (rebuild/q-study/witness/, sha256 23c1c4e5… and 9c22d147…) - 35/03 P. Wernle, *Die synoptische Frage* (Freiburg i. B., 1899); wernle-synoptische-frage-1899, AXN:0C27.ORIGINAL.□□□□□□ - 35/04 J. Weiss, *Das älteste Evangelium* (Göttingen, 1903); weiss-alteste-evangelium-1903, AXN:0C27.ORIGINAL.□□□□□□ - 35/05 J. Wellhausen, *Einleitung in die drei ersten Evangelien* (Berlin, 1905); wellhausen-einleitung-1905, AXN:0C27.ORIGINAL.□□□□□□ - 35/06 A. Harnack, *Sprüche und Reden Jesu: die zweite Quelle des Matthäus und Lukas* (Leipzig, 1907); harnack-spruche-und-reden-1907, AXN:0C27.ORIGINAL.□□□□□□ - 35/07 B. H. Streeter, *The Four Gospels: A Study of Origins* (London, 1924; impression of 1925); streeter-four-gospels-1925, AXN:0C27.ORIGINAL.□□□□□⏏

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The Greek of the censuses: gnt-nestle1904; lxx-swete; josephus; philo; second-temple-pseudepigrapha; justin-dialogus; irenaeus-adversus-haereses; eusebius-historia-ecclesiastica (all at https://www.alexanarch.org/data/corpora/). Plans, scripts and results: rebuild/q-study/census/.

Captures (Capture Registry): 0C22 critical edition of q; 0C23 farrer hypothesis; 0C24 is the q source real; 0C25 q source; 0C26 q source evidence (Google AI Overview, signed out, 2026-11-06); 0C1D, ChatGPT reading #1741 at its record URL (2026-11-06).

Archive: #1735 Revelation First: Literary Genealogy and the Missing Ancestors of the Epistles; #1741 Secondary Source; #1740 EA-CORPORA-34; #851 The Feist Source; #1404 The Feist Source, critical edition with apparatus (Rebekah Cranes, ed.); #1420 The Argument of the Bookshelf.

Declared, outside the commons or not found open: F. Schleiermacher, "Ueber die Zeug-

nisse des Papias von unsern beiden ersten Evangelien” (1832), no open text layer found in session; T. Keim, *Geschichte Jesu von Nazara* (1867–1872), cited through Weiffenbach and not yet read; A. Farrer, “On Dispensing with Q” (1955); J. S. Kloppenborg, *The Formation of Q* (1987); J. M. Robinson, P. Hoffmann and J. S. Kloppenborg, *The Critical Edition of Q* (2000); M. Goodacre, *The Case Against Q* (2002); all in copyright.

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